BONUS · 90 DAYS READY

THE PAYCHECK PLAN

What to buy with each paycheck, in order. About $25–40 a paycheck gets one adult to two weeks ready in eight paychecks.

Shopping list with links: preparedathome.netlify.app/paycheck-plan

STAGE 1 — 72 HOURS

Paychecks 1–4 · about $130 per adult

PAYCHECK 1 — ~$25

- ☐ 3 gallons of water per person — $4
- ☐ Manual can opener — $5
- ☐ Flashlight or headlamp + batteries — $15

PAYCHECK 2 — ~$30

- ☐ 3 days of no-cook food: peanut butter, crackers, canned chicken or tuna, cereal, fruit cups — $20
- ☐ Paper plates, cups, utensils — $5
- ☐ Trash bags and zip-top bags — $5

PAYCHECK 3 — ~$35

- ☐ First-aid kit — $15
- ☐ Pain reliever, allergy medicine — $10
- ☐ Toilet paper, wipes, hand sanitizer — $10

PAYCHECK 4 — ~$40

- ☐ Battery or hand-crank radio (NOAA band) — $25
- ☐ Power bank + phone cable — $15

FREE, ANY WEEK — $0

- ☐ Test smoke and carbon monoxide alarms
- ☐ Photo or copy of IDs and insurance cards
- ☐ Learn where your water and gas shut off
- ☐ Fill clean bottles with tap water, label the date (page 8)

STAGE 2 — 2 WEEKS

Paychecks 5–8 · about $130 per adult

PAYCHECK 5 — ~$30

- ☐ 11 more gallons of water per person, or 2 refillable water jugs — $15–25
- ☐ Plain unscented bleach (page 8) — $4

PAYCHECK 6 — ~$30

- ☐ Week 1 of shelf-stable food you already eat — $25
- ☐ Coffee, drink mixes, a comfort food — $5

PAYCHECK 7 — ~$35

- ☐ Week 2 of shelf-stable food — $25
- ☐ Battery lantern — $10

PAYCHECK 8 — ~$35

- ☐ 2 weeks of your Two-Week Count items (page 3) — $20
- ☐ Extra batteries or a second power bank — $15
- ☐ Ask your pharmacist about early refills — $0

Can't spare $25? Do the free list first, then buy one line per paycheck. Stage 1 is 11 lines, so you still reach 72 hours in about five months of paychecks, and every item helps on its own.
Also on the Stage 1 list (page 4) if your home needs them: 7 days of prescriptions, pet food, baby supplies, spare glasses, a fire extinguisher.

Prices are rough 2026 US big-box estimates for one adult. Yours will vary; multiply water and food by your number of people.

BONUS · 90 DAYS READY

AFTER STAGE 2: THE RHYTHM

From here it's one habit, not a shopping list. Add a little to every grocery trip and let it build.

STAGE 3 · 30 DAYS

Paychecks 9–14

- ☐ Add $15–20 of staples to each grocery run: rice, dried beans, oats, pasta, canned meat
- ☐ One paycheck: a water filter rated for bacteria and protozoa (page 6)
- ☐ Buy 30 days of your Two-Week Count items (× 2), a few each trip
- ☐ Start the pantry log (page 9)

STAGE 4 · 90 DAYS

Paychecks 15–30

- ☐ Same rhythm, $15–25 a paycheck, toward 90 days (× 6.5)
- ☐ Sealed, pest-proof containers for bulk staples
- ☐ Eat the oldest first, replace it on the next trip
- ☐ Ask about 90-day refills for regular medicines

Rule of thumb: buy only what your household already eats and uses. A stocked pantry you rotate is worth more than a stack of food nobody likes.

PAYCHECK	DATE	BUDGET	WHAT I BOUGHT	STAGE	DONE
1				72 hours	☐
2				72 hours	☐
3				72 hours	☐
4				72 hours	☐
5				2 weeks	☐
6				2 weeks	☐
7				2 weeks	☐
8				2 weeks	☐
9				30 days	☐
10				30 days	☐
11				30 days	☐
12				30 days	☐
13				30 days	☐
14				30 days	☐